

Assignment M1

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Abstract—Over the course of the M assignments, I will be investigating the task of searching for local events, with a focus on the Meetup.com website. Meetup.com’s search page currently has two main page views and several filters, but there are some use cases that are difficult to accomplish (for example, searching for certain types of events).

1 PROBLEM SPACE

The task that I will be exploring is searching for local events, specifically using the search page on the Meetup.com website. There are many motivations for finding a local event, and I want to investigate if Meetup.com adequately addresses each of those motivations in their search functionality. For example, a user might be looking for a certain type of event, an event on a certain date or range of dates, an event from a certain group, an event with a certain number of attendees, etc.

The current options on Meetup.com are centered around a "calendar" view and a "group" view. The "calendar" view has a search bar and some filters (such as "your groups only"). The "group" view includes suggestions and a search bar, but no filters. This page does not seem to address all the motivations for users using the page.

Users might be accessing Meetup.com via a computer, a tablet, or a mobile device. If they are using a mobile device, that might indicate that they are doing so while on-the-go (for example, walking while they browse). It is possible that some users might be looking well in advance of the meetup, while others might be searching last-minute in order to bring up the event page and find the address or contact information. In this scenario, they might even be searching while stopped at a red light while driving so that they can check the address of the event.

2 USER TYPES

The user types that I am interested in designing for encompass a broad demographic. I am particularly interested in adult users, but their specific age, loca-

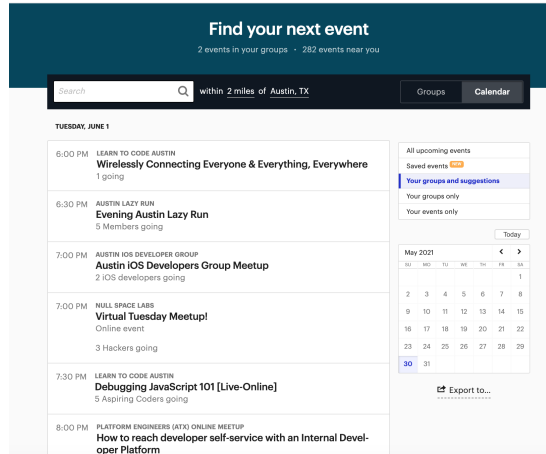


Figure 1—The Meetup.com search page "calendar" view

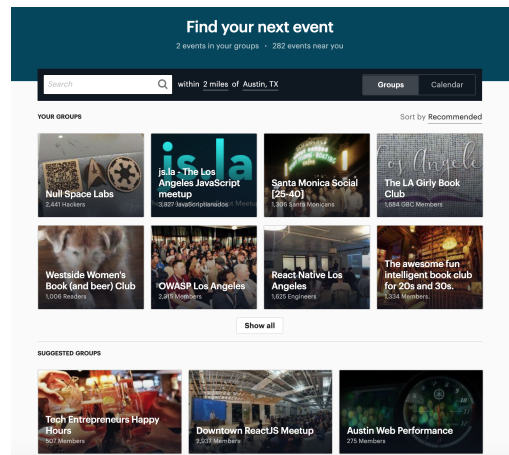


Figure 2—The Meetup.com search page "group" view

tion, and gender are not important. Their level of expertise does not have to be high, but should be enough to be able to use a reasonably designed website or mobile app with ease.

The motivations for engaging in the task, specifically finding a local event, is the most interesting part of the user demographic. I want to design for a wide range of motivations, from finding events for a particular genre (for example, running meetups), to finding events over a range of dates, to finding a particular group's next event, to browsing generally for well-populated events, etc. I suspect that in the needfinding process I will find that users search for events in ways that I am not even considering.

3 NEEDFINDING PLAN 1

3.1 Selection

The first needfinding exercise will be participant observation.

3.2 Plan for Approach

During this exercise, I will go to the Meetup.com website and I will try out specific use cases for finding a local event. The use cases that I will try to evaluate are:

- Finding a particular genre of event (for example, a running meetup)
- Finding events over a range of dates (for example, this weekend)
- Finding the next time a particular group is meeting up (for example, a specific book club)
- Combining multiple filters (for example, finding a running meetup next weekend)

For each of these use cases, I will note details about the process, such as how easy it was to find the information I was looking for, which buttons I needed to press to find the right information, how many events I found, and what information is in the description of the events.

3.3 Connection to Items in Data Inventory

This part of the needfinding plan correlates to the data inventory questions "what do they need", "what are their tasks", and "what are their subtasks".

It helps to answer "what do they need" because the description of the events gives more information for users, which can help me understand what users are looking for. For example, do the events' descriptions just show addresses, or do they point to other websites, or do they give membership information? This can all help illuminate what information the users need.

It also helps to answer "what are their tasks" and "what are their subtasks" because for each of the use cases listed above I can take note of what buttons users need to press and in which order to accomplish those various goals.

It also might answer the question "who are the users" if I happen to find a lot of meetups that are geared towards a particular subset of users. For example, if I

find a lot of meetups for retirees, that tells me more about the age range of who uses the website.

3.4 Potential Biases

Some biases that I will need to avoid in this section are confirmation bias and observer bias. I already have an idea of how I use the website and what I am looking for as a user, so I might have a narrow view of how other users use the site. To avoid this, in the plan above I have already attempted to create use cases that I do not typically engage in and I will use those to get into the mind of other users. I will also look for evidence that I am wrong about how users use the site and will try to use more quantitative and objective data (such as number of buttons/clicks).

4 NEEDFINDING PLAN 2

4.1 Selection

The second needfinding exercise will be a survey.

4.2 Plan for Approach

The survey will ask a variety of questions about users looking for local events. I will send the survey to adults in current social media groups that I am involved in (local Facebook meetup groups, Reddit groups, etc).

The survey will start with some demographic information such as age, location, and how many meetups they have been to in the past year (or in 2019, to account for social distancing and cancellations during COVID-19).

One question that I am interested in understanding from this survey is what the motivation is for finding a local event. Are users looking for a particular type of event? Are they browsing for events over particular dates? Are they browsing for well-attended events regardless of the genre or dates? How many days in advance do they typically search for events (do they search day-of)? What information do they look for in the event description (addresses, another website, etc.)?

Another question that I hope to answer in this survey is what constraints typically have for their events. Do they care how far away the event is? Does the time of day matter to them? Do they want any age restrictions on the event (for

example, adults only)?

Finally, I would like to learn more about how they currently look for events. Do they use Meetup.com, Facebook, Eventbrite, Instagram, a local website, or something else? Do they typically use a mobile device, a tablet, a computer, or another device? Do they typically search for events or do they wait until an event is told to them, such as shared from a friend or seen on Instagram? Do they typically search while stationary such as sitting at home, or are they on-the-go (walking, driving, etc.)?

4.3 Connection to Items in Data Inventory

This part of the needfinding plan correlates to the data inventory questions "who are the users", "where are the users", "what is the context of the task", "what are their goals", and "what do they need".

It helps to answer "who are the users", "where are the users", and "what is the context of the task" because I will ask demographic and background questions to find out their age, location, what devices they use, and in what environment (at home, walking, driving, etc.) they typically search for events.

It also helps to answer "what are their goals" and "what do they need" because I will ask a variety of questions about the users' motivations for finding events and any constraints they have for events. I will also ask for how they currently look for events, which also might reveal what their goals and needs are (for example, if they only use Facebook they might be looking for free events).

4.4 Potential Biases

Some biases that might come up during the survey include "observer bias". In order to avoid this, I will ask peers to review the questions ahead of time to see if I have any leading questions. Another bias that might come up is "voluntary response bias". In order to avoid that, I will not tell participants much about the survey before they take it. Finally, "confirmation bias" might come into play. In order to avoid this, I will add "other" answers to any multiple-choice answers (for questions such as "what platforms do you use to find events") so that I am not biasing my participants towards only platforms that I am familiar with.

5 NEEDFINDING PLAN 3

5.1 Selection

The third needfinding exercise will be an evaluation of existing user interfaces.

5.2 Plan for Approach

First, I will use the answers from the survey to see what other interfaces users currently use to find local meetups. My own experience includes using Facebook, Eventbrite, Instagram, and Reddit to find events, but I will add an "other" option to the survey question so that users can share their own ideas as well. Then, I will use the survey information to choose the 2-3 most popular interfaces to evaluate.

For each of these interfaces, I will try out the same use cases that did in the first needfinding exercise (participant observation):

- Finding a particular genre of event (for example, a running meetup)
- Finding events over a range of dates (for example, this weekend)
- Finding the next time a particular group is meeting up (for example, a specific book club)
- Combining multiple filters (for example, finding a running meetup next weekend)

For each use case and interface, I will take notes on details about the process, such as how easy it was to find the information I was looking for, which buttons I needed to press to find the right information, how many events I found, and what information was available for each event.

5.3 Connection to Items in Data Inventory

This needfinding task helps me answer "who are the users", "where are the users", "what are their goals", "what do they need", "what are their tasks", and "what are their subtasks".

It helps answer questions "who are the users" and "where are the users" because different platforms will naturally have different audiences that gravitate towards them. Therefore, the events that are advertised on each platform might cater to different audiences in different locations.

It helps to answer "what are their goals" and "what do they need" because different platforms will give different information in the events' descriptions. This gives insight into what information users are looking for when they search for events on that particular platform.

Finally, it helps to answer "what are their tasks" and "what are their subtasks" because each platform is going to have a different set of buttons, different filters, different order of operations for finding information, etc.

5.4 Potential Biases

One potential bias is "confirmation bias". I only know how I typically find events as a user, so it is very possible that I will only use the platforms that I am familiar with in ways that I am comfortable. One way that I am mitigating this bias is by asking in the survey (needfinding exercise 2) what platforms they use and what filters they use when searching for events. That way, I can try to evaluate these different platforms the same way the participants of the survey do.

Another potential bias is "recall bias". It is very possible to forget what I have done on each platform after the fact. One way to mitigate that is to actively think out loud or take notes while I am doing the task on each platform so that I do not forget later my thoughts during the task.